

Lab: How the Body Remembers

Objective

Investigate embodied learning through mindfulness practice that compares practiced and novel activities, explores body memory, and observes real-time skill acquisition through the lens of breath, heartbeat, embodied being.

Prerequisites

- A quiet, comfortable space for 25 minutes
- Willingness to engage in mindfulness practice
- No prior experience required

Part 1: Arriving (5 minutes)

Sit comfortably and close your eyes. Take three slow breaths, letting each exhale be longer than the inhale. Bring your attention to the natural rhythm of your breathing without trying to change it.

Perform a well-practiced action (writing your name, a familiar gesture). Notice the ease and automaticity. Now try the same action in an unfamiliar way (non-dominant hand, eyes closed). Feel the contrast.

Write your response here

(Describe the felt difference between practiced and novel action. Where does the body store its learning?)

Part 2: The Body's Library (7 minutes)

Through breath, heartbeat, embodied being, recall three skills your body has learned at different life stages. Let each memory live in the body, not just the mind. Feel the echo of the movement pattern.

Write your response here

(For each skill, describe where the memory lives in your body. What is it like to recall a bodily skill versus a fact?)

Part 3: Real-Time Learning (7 minutes)

Learn a simple new pattern (a rhythm, a gesture sequence, a balance position). Repeat it 10 times. Through breath, heartbeat, embodied being, notice the progression from effortful to more automatic.

Write your response here

(Describe the arc of learning. At what point did the pattern begin to flow? What was changing in your body?)

Part 4: Reflection (5 minutes)

Through breath, heartbeat, embodied being, reflect on what learning means for the body.

Write your response here

(What does the body know that words cannot capture? How does breath, heartbeat, embodied being reveal the nature of embodied learning?)

Reflection Table

Dimension	What I Noticed	Active Inference Connection
Initial awareness		Baseline generative model state
Embodied exploration		Prediction error through direct experience
Breath, heartbeat, embodied being lens		Course-specific perspective on learning
Integration		Updated understanding through bodily knowing

Discussion

Consider how breath, heartbeat, embodied being reveals aspects of learning that other perspectives might miss. In Active Inference, every perspective changes the precision weighting of different signals, revealing different dimensions of the same underlying process of free energy minimization.